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M.A.

DEPARTMENT OF STATE

Memorandum of Conversation

DATE: December 7, 1950

SUBJECT: Truman-Attlee Talks

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PARTICIPANTS:

United Kingdom:
Sir Oliver Franks
Sir Roger Makins
Mr. Robert Scott

United States:
The Secretary of State
Mr. Matthews
Mr. Rusk
Mr. Nitze
Mr. Jessup

COPIES TO:
The Secretary
Mr. Matthews
Mr. Rusk
Mr. Nitze
Mr. Rickerson
Mr. Barnes

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Sir Oliver suggested the desirability of a short meeting tomorrow morning between the President and the Prime Minister to tie things up. Presumably it could not be held before that because the group working on the raw material question would not be ready. This was agreed upon.

There was some discussion as to whether there should be an attempt to draw up agreed conclusions as a private record. It was agreed that there should be a public communique. In regard to that, Sir Oliver said that anything in the Communique on the Far East was very important. In phrasing it, one must keep in mind that the worry in Europe, including the United Kingdom which the Prime Minister has represented in person here, is a very real thing. Sir Roger Makins suggested that the Communique might contain the thought that it had not been the purpose of these meetings to reach conclusions. There was no decision on these matters.

Sir Roger said that the Prime Minister this afternoon would want to make a statement on Indochina since he had talked with the French about this in London. This statement would not contain any concrete request and would not call for action. Mr. Attlee would also say something about Japan, but again there would be no specific points.

The Prime Minister may also touch on the question of US-UK organization and may hand the President a paper on this. He indicated

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that the Prime Minister approved the action which we have taken in sending the letter to M. Schuman, and that we could go ahead with the whole Spofford Plan operation. On the question of the armament effort, he did not think the Prime Minister was yet clear and that this would have to come up later.

Mr. Nitze reported on certain intelligence items which had come to us indicating the possible link between stepped up activities in East Germany and the developments in Asia.

The Secretary then went over orally the memorandum entitled, "United States Position on Two Principal Alternative Courses in Korea." The following reactions were noted. The British agreed on 3a, made no comment on 3b, c, or d. On eiii, they agreed on the importance of the question; and on iv, Sir Oliver agreed on the first sentence. He and Sir Roger agreed that some United Nations forces would have to stay in Korea during the period of negotiations.

On f dealing with Formosa, Sir Oliver asked whether the foreign policy referred to included the following three points:

(1) Continued recognition of Chiang,
(2) Denial of Formosa to the mainland, and
(3) An assertion that in some way and at some time in the future Formosa would belong to China.

He wondered whether this was correct, or whether 2 was the main point. The Secretary said that was at least a starting point, and it was difficult in such matters to use such words as "forever." Sir Oliver said he had raised this question for general reasons.

Skipping to the second course, which is the failure to get a cease-fire, he thought the United States was assuming United Nations support which he thought would be hard to get.

In regard to Formosa, the British recognize the force of the military considerations which we had advanced and their military people also agreed. They were not however impressed by our position on continuing to recognize Chiang-Kai-shek. They understood that the recognition of the Peking Government by the United States was out, but they questioned the continued recognition of Chiang.

The Secretary agreed there was a lot of trouble wrapped up in this problem, and he did not know the answer. If one starts with the proposition that we want to deny Formosa to the mainland, there is no question that Chiang is a factor in this denial. He is on the spot. While we did not like the situation any better than the British do, it is dangerous to talk about the point Sir Oliver raised.

Mr. Scott

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Mr. Scott said he thought there were two alternatives and not three. The first was to make an effort to reach a settlement with the Chinese Communists, and the second was to get into war with them. On the first alternative, he said we must make the effort since so much world opinion and United Nations opinion expected it. Speaking personally, he thought it would be possible to make a settlement. He left to one side the question of recognition of the Chinese Communists by the United States, but they thought that in the United Nations there should be effective representation of China which was not now the case. The United Kingdom does not believe that the conduct of the government is the test to determine whether it should be seated. If they were seated, then they must either comply with their Charter obligations or be denounced. The Secretary asked whether their situation would be any different from that of the Soviet Union. Mr. Scott said no but Chinese Communists were now outlaws and there was much support of the idea that they ought to have the seat in the United Nations. The United Kingdom would like to put this to the test and see how they behave. He then analyzed their arguments about the way in which they were merely helping North Korea which is a government they had recognized, and he said they made out "quite a strong legal case" which appeals to a great many.

Mr. Scott then argued that we should try to establish a position of consistent and unwavering policy. Regarding Formosa, we had once said it was of no strategic importance and now we say it is. We ought to reaffirm the Cairo Declaration. In doing so, we would say it must stand or fall as a whole. We would argue that the part on Korea is the most important and that, before we looked at the question of Formosa and other questions, we should get implementation of the agreement on Korea. We should point out that this is a new Chinese Government which has repudiated some of the earlier Chinese obligations and we should ask whether they accept the principles of the Cairo Declaration which includes the renunciation of aggression and of any desire for territory. These general principles were stated in the Declaration in regard to Japan, but they were of general application. If China accepted them, that would be good. He did not think this course would settle the whole Far Eastern problem, but if war broke out in the East it would become a world war. At that point Korea would be very similar to the case of Greece in World War II. He admitted that the success of the policy he outlined was doubtful, but it would carry world opinion with us. It would safeguard both Korea and Formosa. It would show that our policy is not based on expediency and opportunism, but is consistent. He stressed the responsibility of the United Nations regarding Korea and said that his proposal offered the only hope for a United Nations solution regarding Korea.

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The United Nations

The United Nations might be able to do its job if the Chinese Communists were seated instead of having the United Nations inthe ingenuous position of negotiating with outlaws.

The Secretary, without commenting on the proposals, inquired whether in the end this policy would mean that both Korea and Formosa would be in communist hands.

Mr. Scott recalled that, even before the present situation developed, we had both felt that at some time Korea might become communist. This was a risk but the risk would exist under any plan, for example, if we had all-Korean elections. He did not know whether under this plan Formosa would eventually be in communist hands, but this plan would not increase our risks.

The Secretary said that, while it was true Mr. Scott had outlined what might be considered a consistent and logical policy, he feared the end of it would be grave danger. He mentioned that as a matter of fact we did give Formosa to China but said that he did not wish to prolong the discussion by arguing what might seem to be merely a lawyer's point.

Sir Oliver said he would like to recall certain elements of British foreign policy over the last two centuries. They had never been a large land power and therefore they had always had to act on the basis of working with other countries. The United States, in addition to being a sea and air power, was also a large land power with all of the industrial capacity which that involved. He thought, however, even if this great power of the United States were contrasted with the large world mass, the United States would need to accept the same principle which the British had followed. This principle of solidarity with other countries now works, whether for good or ill, through the United Nations.

The meeting had to adjourn so that the Secretary and Sir Oliver could keep a luncheon engagement.

Philip C. Jessup
Ambassador at Large

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